CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

Tuesday, October 20, 2026

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RE: Haines attack leaves MP critical, driver charged · ADF opens PNG recruitment under Pukpuk Treaty · NZ signs $1.6b Seahawk deal · ADF war-games AUKUS subs against China · ADB approves $40.1m fuel support

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
8,817	0.6992	13,632	0.5684
+0.38%	+0.10%	-0.86%	+1.25%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · AUKUS · Pacific · New Zealand · China-Pacific · Canberra · Markets · Upcoming · The Wire · Analysis

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Canberra opened Australian Defence Force recruitment to Papua New Guinean university students under a $65 million Pukpuk Treaty trial aiming for 100 recruits over two years.
2. Wellington signed a NZ$1.6 billion deal with the US government for five Seahawk helicopters and weapons, one of the largest single buys yet under the Defence Capability Plan.
3. Melbourne's Alfred Hospital is treating independent MP Helen Haines in critical condition after a car attack Prime Minister Anthony Albanese called a deliberate act, with the driver facing a Commonwealth charge.

TOP STORIES

AU-POLITICS

Independent MP Helen Haines critical after Wangaratta car attack

Independent MP **Helen Haines**, 65, remains in critical condition at Melbourne's Alfred hospital after a white Toyota LandCruiser struck her twice outside her Wangaratta electorate office on Monday afternoon. Police charged 43-year-old **Brendan Nugent** with dangerous driving causing serious injury, intentionally causing serious injury, and the Commonwealth offence of causing harm to a Commonwealth public official. A knife was found in the vehicle. Prime Minister **Anthony Albanese** said the joint counterterrorism unit had been activated and that the incident was "a deliberate act".

per RNZ Pacific (wire): "Australian MP Helen Haines in critical condition after being hit by car outside office" · also The Washington Post

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

ADF opens recruitment to PNG university students under Pukpuk Treaty

The Australian Defence Force will open recruitment to Papua New Guinean university students from next month under a *$65 million* trial, announced at a ministerial meeting in Port Moresby. The pilot aims to recruit 100 young Papua New Guineans over two years, with the first cohort expected to be sworn in by late 2027. Recruits will enlist on temporary visas and must eventually obtain Australian citizenship to continue serving. The Pukpuk Treaty, in force since July, lets each country recruit the other's citizens and obliges both to defend each other if attacked.

per ABC News (Marian Faa): "Australian military opens its ranks to PNG university students" · also The Australian

NZ-DEFENSE

New Zealand signs $1.6 billion deal for five Seahawk helicopters

New Zealand signed a *NZ$1.6 billion* agreement with the US government for five Seahawk maritime helicopters, anti-submarine torpedoes, and air-to-surface missiles, one of the biggest single purchases so far under the Defence Capability Plan. Washington approved the sale in June under its Foreign Military Sale system. The Lockheed Martin subsidiary-built aircraft arrive at Whenuapai air base from 2030 and will cost an additional $110 million a year to operate, with further funding needed to upgrade the base. The NZDF cited Australia's operation of Seahawks as a factor.

per RNZ: "New Zealand signs $1.6 billion deal to buy five navy helicopters and weapons"

OVERNIGHT

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Maru welcomes Australian delegation to 32nd Australia-PNG Ministerial Forum · PNG Post-Courier

PNG Minister for International Trade and Investment **Richard Maru** welcomed an Australian delegation to Port Moresby for the 32nd Australia-PNG Ministerial Forum, held at APEC Haus. Islands Business reported the two governments are working to turn the new alliance into defence and economic action. The forum convened the same day Canberra opened ADF recruitment to Papua New Guineans.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

ADB approves $40.1 million to cushion Kiribati, Tonga, Tuvalu fuel costs · Islands Business

The Asian Development Bank approved *$40.1 million* to help Kiribati, Tonga, and Tuvalu manage rising fuel costs. The three states import nearly all their liquid fuel, and Brent crude closed at 111.56 on Tuesday, up 5.32 percent.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Four Pacific nations face possible loss of US aid · Islands Business

PACNEWS reports mounting warnings from Washington that four Pacific nations risk losing US aid. The same bulletin carried Vanuatu Prime Minister's statement that the government remains stable despite leadership challenge claims, and competing Fijian positions on parliamentary powers over the Great Council of Chiefs.

NZ-POLITICS

Luxon and Hipkins meet for final leaders' debate as health dominates · RNZ

Christopher Luxon and Labour leader **Chris Hipkins** faced off for the third time on Stuff, with health the central issue. Hipkins challenged Luxon to a dedicated health debate, saying the system is in crisis. Health sits second on the Ipsos Issues Monitor behind cost of living, and Labour released a plan for emergency-department improvements ahead of the debate.

TRADE-ECONOMY

RBA payments chief defends card surcharge ban · AFR

In his first public appearance since the ban came into force, Reserve Bank of Australia payments chief **Ellis Connolly** said price transparency for consumers would be a major benefit of the change. The AFR reported the comments as retailers continue to contest the reform's cost allocation.

US-CHINA-PACIFIC

US issues final leasing notice for 31.4 million acres off American Samoa · Pacific Island Times

The Marine Minerals Administration issued the final leasing notice for a seabed minerals lease sale offshore American Samoa, covering two areas totalling *31.4 million acres*, the last step before an award set for November 19. Earthjustice is seeking to halt the auction.

STAT OF THE DAY

$65 million

ADF trial recruiting PNG university students

Canberra will spend it to recruit 100 Papua New Guineans over two years under the Pukpuk Treaty, the first foreign-national recruitment pathway of its kind announced at the Port Moresby ministerial forum.

ABC News

AUKUS WATCH

PILLAR 1 · SMH WORLD

ADF war-games use of nuclear-powered submarines in a China conflict

The Australian Defence Force is taking part in war games this week simulating a regional conflict with China and testing how US submarines, and those Australia is to acquire under AUKUS, would be employed. The Sydney Morning Herald reported the exercise from North America.

PILLAR 1 · ASPI STRATEGIST

ASPI: a defence factory in Western Australia is not a defence capability

Delivering Defence's naval shipbuilding and sustainment requirements in Western Australia will take more than new investment and infrastructure, ASPI argues, pointing to the state's established resources sector, heavy-industry facilities, and engineering expertise as the existing industrial base to draw on.

PACIFIC WIRE

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC

Lou Island villagers plead for aerial help as bushfire burns for two weeks

A fire burning for almost two weeks on Lou Island in Manus Province has destroyed large areas of forest and food gardens and is tracking toward Lako and Rei, where about 700 people live. **Ngenge Sasa** of Rei village said locals are fighting it with seawater and have asked Australia and New Zealand for help after PNG disaster authorities said they lack the equipment.

FIJI · AFP

Middle East fuel crunch drives solar push in Fiji

A Middle East fuel crunch is accelerating Fiji's move into solar generation, AFP reported. Brent crude settled at *111.56* on Tuesday, up 5.32 percent, compounding the import-cost pressure on Pacific states dependent on diesel for power.

TUVALU · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Tuvalu takes the Central Pacific Shipping Commission chair from Kiribati

Kiribati handed the chair of the Central Pacific Shipping Commission to Tuvalu following the commission's annual general meeting. Tuvalu will host the next round of shipping talks.

KIRIBATI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Butaritari hosts 12th Central Pacific Shipping Commission AGM

Butaritari, Kiribati's northernmost island, hosted the 12th annual general meeting of the Central Pacific Shipping Commission, bringing regional cargo and transport officials to one of the most remote atolls in the grouping.

REGIONAL · PACIFIC ISLAND TIMES

Funding gaps threaten Pacific push for cleaner shipping

Pacific island countries face mounting obstacles to modernising ageing shipping fleets, with limited financing, inadequate infrastructure, and shortages of technical expertise threatening efforts to cut fuel dependence without making essential transport more expensive.

REGIONAL · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Pacific churches reject US call to end UN decolonisation mandate

Pacific churches rejected a United States call to wind up the UN decolonisation mandate, PACNEWS reported. The same bulletin carried IPCC chair Skea warning against excluding vulnerable nations from IPCC decisions, and Pacific leaders discussing development priorities with Israel.

PALAU · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Palau stays Tier 2 in US trafficking report as prosecutions stall

Palau remained at Tier 2 in the United States human trafficking report, with prosecutions stalled, PACNEWS reported. The same bulletin recorded Vanuatu's exemption from Australian international student visa measures.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY · REUTERS

New Zealand adds Brazil and Canada trade talks as India pact starts

Wellington is adding trade negotiations with Brazil and Canada as its agreement with India comes into effect, Reuters reported. The diversification push comes 18 days out from the general election.

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

Year-end inflation surge points to more New Zealand rate rises

A year-end surge in New Zealand inflation points toward further Reserve Bank of New Zealand rate increases, Bloomberg reported. The New Zealand dollar traded at 0.5684 against the US dollar on Tuesday, up 1.25 percent, while the NZX 50 closed at 13,632, down 0.86 percent.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

New Zealand records best ever pension index result, Australia reaches A grade

New Zealand scored a B and placed 15th of 55 systems in the Marsh CFA Institute Global Pension Index, its best result, lifted by higher net income replacement rates and household savings. Australia joined the A-rated group for the first time. Lead author **Tim Jenkins** said adequacy, where New Zealand ranks 34th, remains the weak point.

CHINA IN THE PACIFIC

VANUATU · SECURITY AGREEMENT · ABC PACIFIC

Vanuatu confirms reduction of Chinese police presence under Nakamal Agreement

The Vanuatu government will reduce the Chinese police presence in the country in line with the Nakamal Agreement with Australia, ABC Pacific reported, following last week's reporting that Port Vila expected the numbers to fall.

REGIONAL · MILITARY FACILITY · ABC NEWS

China and Laos inaugurate joint pilot training centre at former CIA airfield

China and Laos opened the China-Laos Joint Support and Training Centre at a newly built airfield at Ban Keun, about 50 kilometres north of Vientiane, on September 29. China's Ministry of National Defense said the jointly operated facility will train Laotian air force pilots. Beijing holds few declared overseas military facilities, among them South China Sea installations and a base in Djibouti.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Husic presses Chalmers on growth, speculates on Albanese retirement

Labor MP **Ed Husic** urged Treasurer **Jim Chalmers** to "unshackle the economy" and speculated about the Prime Minister's retirement, adding to a widening set of critiques of the government's economic strategy from party-aligned figures, the Sydney Morning Herald's **Paul Sakkal** reported.

AU-POLITICS · POLITICO

Lobbyists rebrand as One Nation surges in the polls

Australia's lobbying industry is repositioning as One Nation rises in published polling, Politico reported from Canberra. The shift follows the party's growing share of the minor-party vote and its increased prominence in federal debate.

AU-POLITICS · SMH

Security agencies warn political extremism has reached boiling point

Australia's security agencies warned that political extremism has reached a boiling point as serving politicians say they fear for their own safety, the Sydney Morning Herald reported in the wake of the attack on Helen Haines.

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

Nationals withhold support for the EU trade agreement

The Nationals will not support the Australia-EU trade agreement, SBS chief political correspondent **Anna Henderson** told ABC Radio National, alongside continuing tensions between the Prime Minister and Treasurer over the ATO's move to end credit card payments.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Islamophobia envoy criticises rushed racism definitions

Australia's Islamophobia envoy criticised what the envoy described as rushed official definitions of racism, warning against creating a "hierarchy of pain", The Australian reported.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Aged care providers warn migration cuts could deepen staff shortages

Aged care providers warned that cuts to migration intakes could worsen existing workforce shortages, the ABC reported, as the sector presses for visa safeguards for migrant workers.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFR

BHP pledges to double Australian copper output by 2040

BHP committed an initial *$1.1 billion* to a growth program that could consume almost $64 billion over the coming decade, with the aim of doubling its Australian copper production by 2040, the Australian Financial Review reported.

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFR

Japanese pension fund makes first direct Australian clean energy investment

One of the world's largest public retirement savings funds has made its first direct investment in Australia's clean energy rollout, the AFR reported, adding Japanese institutional capital to the renewables buildout.

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFR

NAB to cut 2,500 jobs, about six percent of its workforce

National Australia Bank will cut roughly *2,500 jobs*, about six percent of its workforce, by mid-2027. The AFR's Chanticleer column attributed the decision to two forces it said should resonate across Australia's white-collar employment base. The ASX 200 closed at 8,817, up 0.38 percent.

TRADE-ECONOMY · RNZ

Rabobank says GLP-1 demand shift favours New Zealand protein exports

Rabobank's report, New Zealand's protein moment, found tight global beef and sheepmeat supply will support near-term prices, with longer-term value depending on market diversification and reliable delivery. Senior animal protein analyst **Jen Corkran** said US surveys suggest nearly one in eight adults has used a GLP-1 medication for weight loss.

UPCOMING

OCT 26

Advance voting opens for the New Zealand general election

Early voting begins while health and inflation dominate the campaign, days after the final leaders' debate.

NOV 7

New Zealand general election

Decides whether the National-ACT-NZ First coalition continues the Defence Capability Plan that produced the NZ$1.6 billion Seahawk purchase.

NOV 19

US seabed minerals lease sale award offshore American Samoa

First such award in American Samoan waters, covering 31.4 million acres, with litigation pending to stop it.

MAR
2027

PNG inaugural China business forum and trade expo

Port Moresby's deferred trade event will set the commercial baseline for PNG-China engagement alongside the Australian alliance.

THE WIRE

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Devpolicy: in-line placements outperformed today's aid facilities

Mark Moran returns to Lesotho decades after building water systems that still run, and argues in-line postings produced more durable results than the contracted "facility" model that now dominates Australian aid delivery.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

RNZ PACIFIC

New Zealand High Court declines injunction in PNG Chiefs trademark dispute

The High Court declined New Zealand Rugby's bid for an interim injunction over the PNG Chiefs name, leaving the trademark dispute bound for a substantive trial next year. NZ Rugby could also litigate in Australia, where it holds the trademark.

ABC PACIFIC

Inside the Pacific's golden passport schemes

ABC Pacific examines citizenship-by-investment programs across the region, with one participant describing them as "selling our identity".

ABC PACIFIC

Kiribati expedition finds no trace of Amelia Earhart's aircraft

An international expedition organised by Purdue University and the Archaeological Legacy Institute concluded the object seen in satellite images of Nikumaroro's lagoon was most likely a collection of trees. Original identifier **Mike Ashmore** said better imagery made him doubt his own theory.

ANALYSIS AND OPINION

THE DIPLOMAT

How the Fossil Fuel Industry 'Captured' Australia and Maintains Its Political Dominance

The article traces how fossil fuel interests embedded themselves in Australian political argument. It contends the framing, rather than the economics, sustains the sector's influence over energy policy.

Argument: Framing coal and gas as essential to jobs, prosperity, and national identity lets the industry resist the renewable transition.

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